JIANG NAN 江南	**Thawing Policy**	Document No.:	IKQAP#010
		Revision No.	1
	Imperial Kitchen Group Inc.,	Effective Date:	June 28, 2026

1. Purpose

To establish rigorous controls that ensure food safety and maintain product quality throughout the entire thawing process at Imperial Kitchen Group Inc.. To guarantee these standards are met, the policy strictly enforces the utilization of only four approved thawing methods, explicitly prohibiting hazardous practices such as thawing at room temperature on a counter or a loading dock. Furthermore, it outlines comprehensive monitoring, documentation, and labeling requirements for all items transferred to cold storage to uphold strict inventory control and safeguard food safety. Finally, this policy defines clear corrective action protocols and administrative rework authorization procedures to systematically address operational deviations, biological cross-contamination, and unexpected temperature variations.

2. Scope

The scope of this policy applies to all kitchen employees, captains, and QA involved in the execution, supervision, and validation of approved thawing methods, including chiller, running water, and direct cooking techniques.

3. Responsibilities

3.1. Kitchen Captain

Shall be the primary accountable for long-term production forecasting, inventory flow, and systemic oversight of the thawing process. Additionally, the Captain is responsible for optimizing chest freezer and outdoor freezer-refrigerator shelf space by enforcing strict "First In, First Out" (FIFO) protocols and ensuring that all thawing items are placed exclusively on the lowest shelves to mitigate cross-contamination risks. Beyond spatial management, they must conduct daily audits of the Kitchen Employees' Thaw Logs to catch omissions early, signing off on these records at the end of each shift to verify that no frozen products were rushed or subjected to unsafe ambient temperatures.

3.2. Kitchen Employees

Shall be responsible for the hands-on execution, continuous monitoring, and meticulous documentation of the daily thawing workflow. Employees must manage the Thaw Log in real-time, documenting the exact timestamp a product is pulled from freezer storage, the specific approved method utilized—such as Refrigerated Thawing or Running Water Thawing—and the precise internal temperature of the product upon completion. During execution, employees are required to strictly adhere to established food safety protocols tailored to the chosen method; for example, when utilizing the running water method, they must verify that the water completely submerges the product and drains continuously without splashing onto surrounding clean surfaces. Upon completion of the thaw cycle, employees must use a calibrated, sanitized stem thermometer to check the core internal temperature of the product, confirming it has remained safely out of the Temperature Danger Zone before it is transferred to active line preparation.

3.3. Restaurant & Shift Managers

Shall be centrally focused on orchestrating the kitchen’s operational rhythm by meticulously analyzing historical sales data, upcoming event catering orders, and daily preparation forecasts to map out comprehensive weekly production schedules. This deliberate, data-driven planning guarantees that high-risk proteins are systematically transferred from the freezers with adequate lead time, ensuring a safe, uninterrupted refrigerated thawing cycle that strictly aligns with health department regulations. Furthermore, they must continuously monitor inventory velocity and cross-reference prep lists with real-time shifts in guest counts to prevent both costly over-production and critical ingredient shortages. By actively auditing the execution of these schedules and coaching the line staff on proper rotation, managers bridge the gap between back-of-house compliance and financial efficiency, ultimately safeguarding food quality while maximizing restaurant profitability.

3.4. Quality Assurance (QA)

Shall provides unbiased, systematic validation of all thawing activities through rigorous auditing and regulatory enforcement. In addition to physical floor checks, the QA also performs comprehensive reviews of all physical and digital Thaw Logs to safeguard data integrity, looking for

patterns of non-compliance, missing supervisor signatures, or inconsistencies to ensure the facility remains perpetually audit-ready for external regulatory health inspections. When a thawing deviation is flagged, the QA Department takes charge of the corrective action oversight, evaluating the incident to determine if the affected product can be safely salvaged via specialized methods or if it mandates total product condemnation and disposal. To prevent future failures, QA also drives continuous improvement by managing periodic retraining sessions for the kitchen staff and enforcing a strict, documented schedule for the regular calibration of all food service thermometers.

4. Principles of Safe Thawing

Bacteria grow rapidly in the Temperature Danger Zone between 4°C (40°F) and 60°C (140°F). To prevent foodborne illness, Imperial Kitchen Group Inc. strictly prohibits thawing food at room temperature (e.g., leaving frozen meat on a countertop). Only the following four methods are permitted. Thawing at room temperature (on a counter or loading dock) is strictly prohibited.

4.1. Refrigerated Thawing

To ensure food safety and maintain product quality, refrigerator thawing requires a bit of foresight and the right environmental controls. Start by planning ahead and moving items from the freezer into a dedicated thawing refrigerator or walk-in cooler. For this method to be effective and safe, the unit must be strictly maintained at a temperature of 5°C (41°F) or below. Organization is equally important for hygiene; always place thawing items on the bottom shelves to prevent any juices from dripping onto other foods and causing cross-contamination. Finally, remember that patience is a virtue here—while smaller items thaw faster, larger items such as whole turkeys or large roasts typically require a duration of 2–3 days to thaw completely.

4.2. Cold Running Water Thawing

To thaw food safely using the cold running water method, submerge the product in its original leak-proof packaging under running potable water. The water temperature must be strictly maintained at 21°C (70°F) or below, with a flow strong enough to agitate the product, float off loose particles, and continuously overflow the container. It is vital to manage the timing carefully to ensure the food temperature does not exceed 5°C (41°F) for more than 4 hours—a limit that encompasses the total cumulative time for thawing, preparation, and cooling.

4.3. Microwave Thawing

Thawing food in the microwave is a quick alternative, but it must be handled with specific safety precautions. This method should be used only for small portions that are intended to be cooked immediately after the thawing cycle is complete. Furthermore, microwave thawing is only permitted if the product moves directly to the next stage and completes the full cooking process in conventional cooking equipment, such as ovens or grills, to ensure food safety and quality.

4.4. Thawing as Part of Cooking

For certain products, such as frozen hamburger patties, vegetables, or small seafood, thawing is not always necessary as they may be cooked directly from a frozen state. When using this method, it is a strict requirement to verify the "Kill Step" using a calibrated thermometer. This ensures that the internal temperature reaches the required regulatory minimum to effectively eliminate harmful pathogens and ensure the food is safe for consumption.

5. Compliance & Monitoring

5.1. **Thaw Log:** Employee must record the start time, method used, and the internal temperature of the product upon completion of thawing.

5.2. **Labeling:** To maintain food safety and inventory control, all items transferred to the refrigerator must be clearly labeled with the following information:

- **Item Name:** The specific common name of the product.
- **Date Stored :** The exact calendar date the item was moved into cold storage.
- **"Use By" Date:** The expiration date calculated based on the specific product type. For most items, this is typically **48–72 hours** after the product has reached a complete thaw.

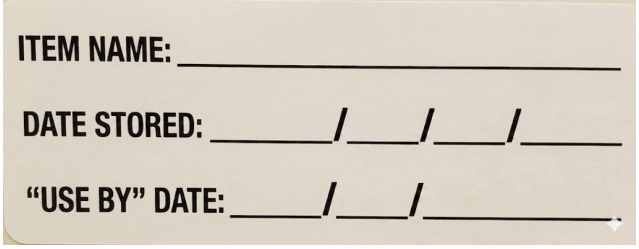


Figure 1. Sample label

6. Corrective Actions

6.1. Conversion to "Cooked-Only" Status (Rework for Cross-Contamination)

When a "Ready-to-Eat" (RTE) item or a raw ingredient intended for cold processing becomes cross-contaminated by raw meat juices, immediate disposal is not the only recourse. The item may be redirected to a production line that utilizes a validated thermal kill step, such as stewing, roasting, or high-heat frying, to neutralize the risk. For this rework to be successful, the internal temperature of the food must reach a minimum of 74°C (165°F), ensuring that any biological pathogens introduced by the Meat drips are effectively eliminated. However, this protocol is strictly limited to cases of biological contamination; if the meat juice contains physical hazards (like bone fragments) or chemical hazards, the item cannot be salvaged and must be discarded.

6.2. Rapid Chill & Repurpose (Rework for Temperature Deviation)

If a product is discovered thawing in standing water but has maintained an internal temperature no higher than 5°C (41°F), it may be reconditioned through a specific corrective action rather than being discarded. The item must be immediately removed from the water, patted dry using single-use towels,and transferred to a blast chiller to rapidly return it to a safe holding temperature. To ensure food safety, verification with a calibrated probe thermometer is mandatory; if any portion of the product's surface has reached or exceeded 21°C (70°F), the item is considered unsafe and the recovery option is void. Once stabilized, the product must be clearly labeled as "Priority Use" and processed or cooked within a strict 12-hour window.

6.3. Trimming and Surface Remediation

For large, solid muscle meats, such as whole beef sub-primals, that have been exposed to minor surface contamination, a "Clean Trim" procedure may be performed as a corrective action. This process involves a trained technician removing the outer 1.5 cm of the affected surface area using a strictly sanitized knife to ensure all potential contaminants are excised. To maintain the integrity of the product, this trimming must be conducted in a high-care area, which prevents the newly exposed tissue from being re-contaminated during the procedure. However, this method is strictly restricted to solid muscles; it is prohibited for use on ground meats, comminuted products, or porous items like bread and sliced vegetables, as pathogens in those products can migrate beyond the surface level.

6.4. Rework Authorization Protocol

Before any reconditioning or rework operation can commence, a strict set of administrative and safety protocols must be satisfied. First, a Quality Assurance (QA) evaluation is mandatory, where a representative assesses the extent of the deviation to determine if the product is a candidate for rework. All details of the process must then be documented in a Rework Log, including the lot number, the specific reason for the rework, and the corrective method employed. Once the process is complete, a final disposition is required; the finished product must be sampled and successfully pass a microbial limit test—such as an *E. coli* or *Salmonella* swab—before it is cleared for sale, with the intensity of testing dictated by the severity of the initial breach. Finally, it is important to note that while converting a product to a cooked ingredient may resolve safety concerns, it can trigger labeling non-compliance if the item was originally marketed as "Fresh" or "Never Cooked," as the final state must accurately match its legal description.

7. Change History

Revision No.:	Revision Date:	Author & Position:	Purpose of Revision
0	April 21, 2026	Celine Joy Sanchez**, QA Specialist**	Originator
1	May 25, 2026	Celine Joy Sanchez**, QA Specialist**	• Added Responsibilities

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